



CASE STUDY

We built the right product for the wrong buyer



My role: Co-founder, Product & Design

I worked across product design and product management. I owned customer discovery, JTBD, product definition, information architecture, UX, roadmap prioritization and PRDs, while partnering with other co-founders on product direction and execution.

The starting point

CopilotGTM started with a simple observation. Presales teams spent a lot of time piecing together information before, during and after customer conversations. Information lived across conversations, documents, proposals, RFPs, product material and sales context. Even simple questions could require digging through several sources. We believed AI could remove much of that manual work.

Our initial hypothesis

Persona: Presales / Sales Engineering

Problem: Too much time spent finding information, preparing responses and creating sales collateral.

Initial product: An AI copilot that could help presales teams:

- Prepare for customer conversations
 - Answer ad hoc questions during sales calls
 - Create proposals
 - Respond to RFPs
 - Find relevant customer and product information
 - The first version was designed around those workflows.
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We started with real users

We worked with five U.S. presales leaders as design partners. They used the product for several weeks. The encouraging part was that they liked it. They saw value in the workflows and told us they would pay for it.

But when we tried to move toward a purchase, something unexpected happened. The people who used the product did not control the budget. The presales leaders could advocate for the product, but the budget sat with the VP Sales.

That meant we had validated one thing:

"This is useful to me."

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But we had not validated the more important question:

"Will the organization pay for this?"

That distinction changed the way I thought about product validation.

The second signal came from India

Around the same time, we started speaking with sales teams in India. We found another important difference. Many companies did not have a separate presales function. Salespeople were doing much of the work themselves. And many of the problems overlapped:

Prepare for a call → Understand customer context → Run the call → Follow up → Manage Stakeholders → Move the deal forward

Now two signals were pointing in the same direction.

Signal 1: Presales users valued the product, but were not the budget owners.

Signal 2: Sales teams were already performing many of the same workflows and were much closer to the commercial outcome.

So we asked a different question.

What if the product was not really about helping presales work faster?

The pivot

FROM PRESALES ASSISTANCE TO REVENUE INTELLIGENCE

We changed:

Persona: Presales → Sales and Sales Leadership

Problem: Help me perform my GTM work → Help me understand and move the deal forward

Value Proposition: Information and task assistance → Intelligence, risk detection and intervention

The pivot was ultimately a unanimous founder decision. The original product direction came from the CEO. As the product evolved, I played a major role in shaping the product strategy, discovery and experience around the new direction.

The lesson was not simply that presales was the wrong persona. It was that user pain, buyer value and budget ownership are three different things.

Reframing the problem

Sales teams already had systems for storing activity.

- CRM showed deal status.
- Call intelligence captured conversations.
- Spreadsheets and reviews captured additional context.

But the information was still fragmented. The harder questions were:

What changed?

Is this deal gaining or losing momentum? If yes, why?

What puts the deal at risk?

Who is influencing the outcome?

What should I do next?

That shifted our product thinking from: Information retrieval → **Decision intelligence**

Designing the new product

Once we changed the problem, the product expanded around the actual sales workflow. I worked with the founding team to identify the highest-value problems and decide what to build first. The roadmap was driven primarily by:

Customer conversations → recurring needs → Jobs-to-be-Done → business value → prioritization

We did not try to build everything at once.

We repeatedly deprioritized functionality that was interesting but not essential to the immediate product direction.

THE PRODUCT

01. Prepare before the call

The problem

Salespeople often had to reconstruct previous conversations from memory before every meeting.

What happened last time?

What was promised?

Who was involved?

What is the objective of today's call?

The solution: Briefing Room

The system brought together previous context, upcoming meeting information and stakeholder details to help prepare for the conversation.

The experience could provide:

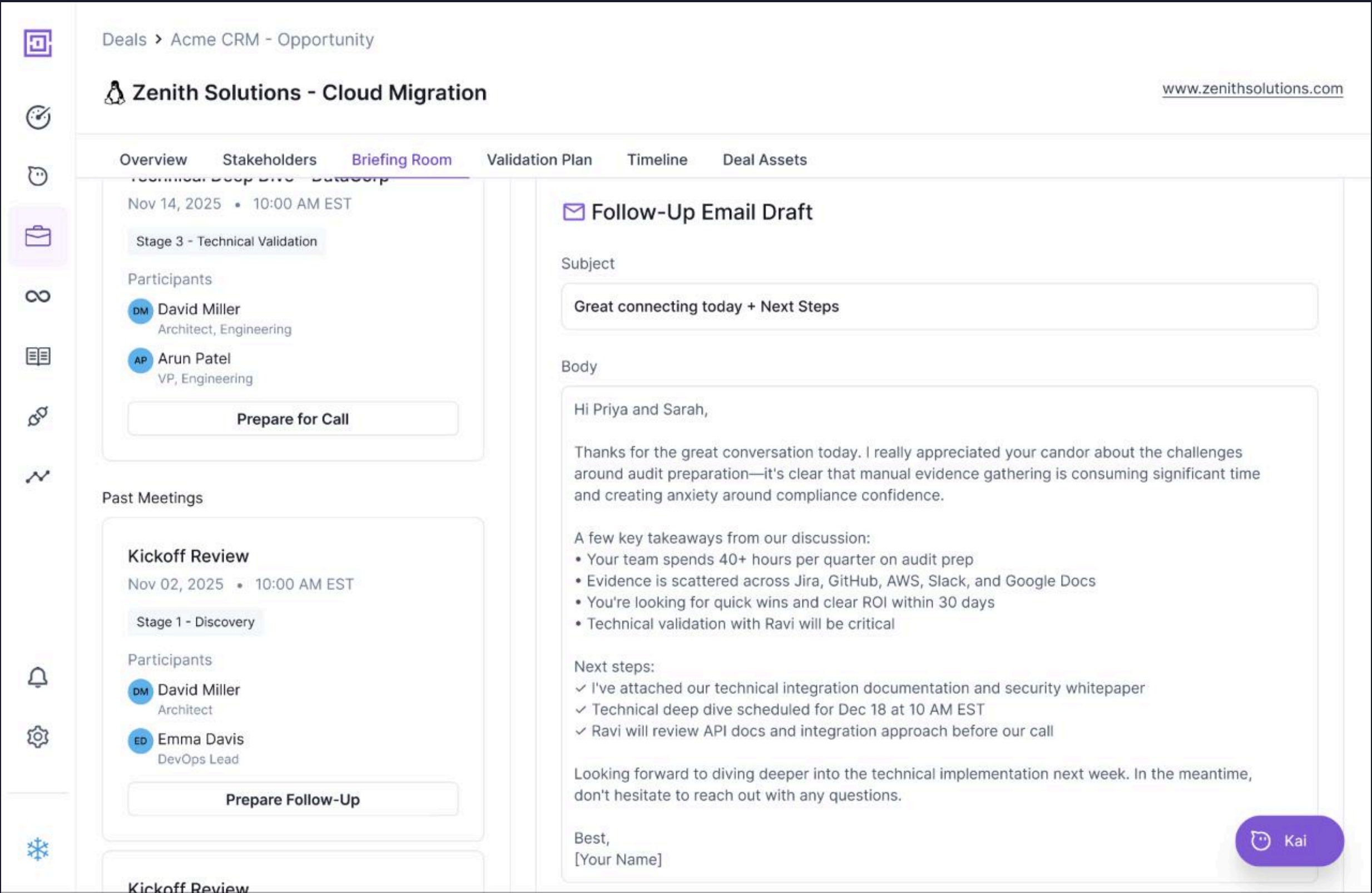
- Meeting recap
- Customer pain points
- Stakeholders attending
- Objections and rebuttals
- Narrative guidance
- Suggested call flow
- Recommended questions

02. Follow up after the call

The next problem appeared immediately after the meeting.
Important information from the conversation needed to turn into action.
We created:

Meeting recap → Action items → Follow-up email

The system generated a recap, identified next steps and drafted the follow-up based on the current conversation and previous context.
This turned the product from a passive repository into an active part of the workflow.



03. Understand the deal

The product then moved toward a central question:

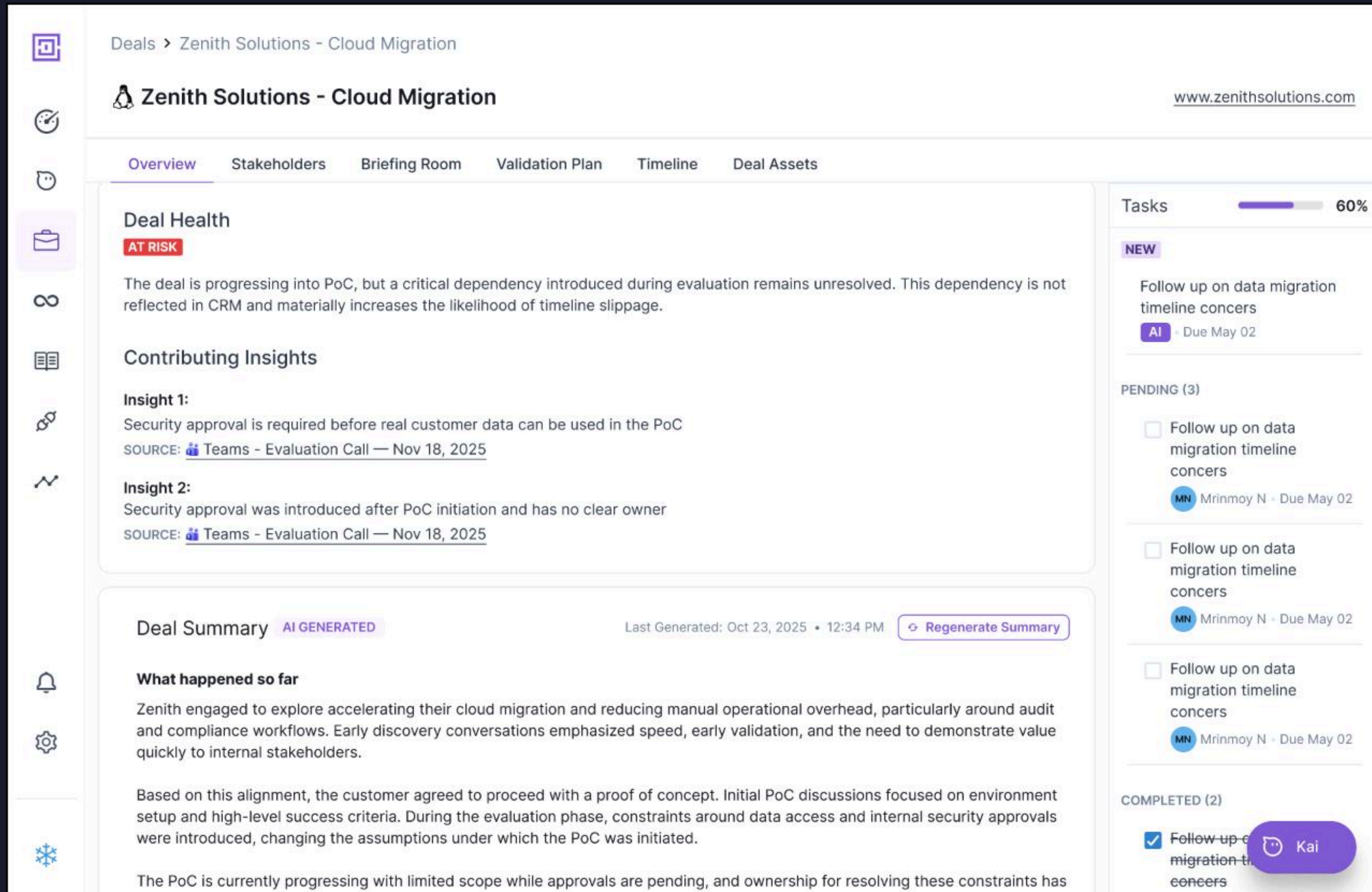
What is actually happening in this deal?

The Deal Overview brought together:

- Deal context
- Current stage
- Deal health
- Contributing insights
- AI-generated summary
- Risks
- Blockers
- Sources
- Tasks
- Connected channels

The intent was to give the salesperson or sales leader a common understanding of the deal without forcing them to reconstruct it manually.

Screen: Deal Overview



04. See the deal unfold over time

A snapshot is not enough to understand a deal. The team also needed to understand how the story evolved.

Timeline

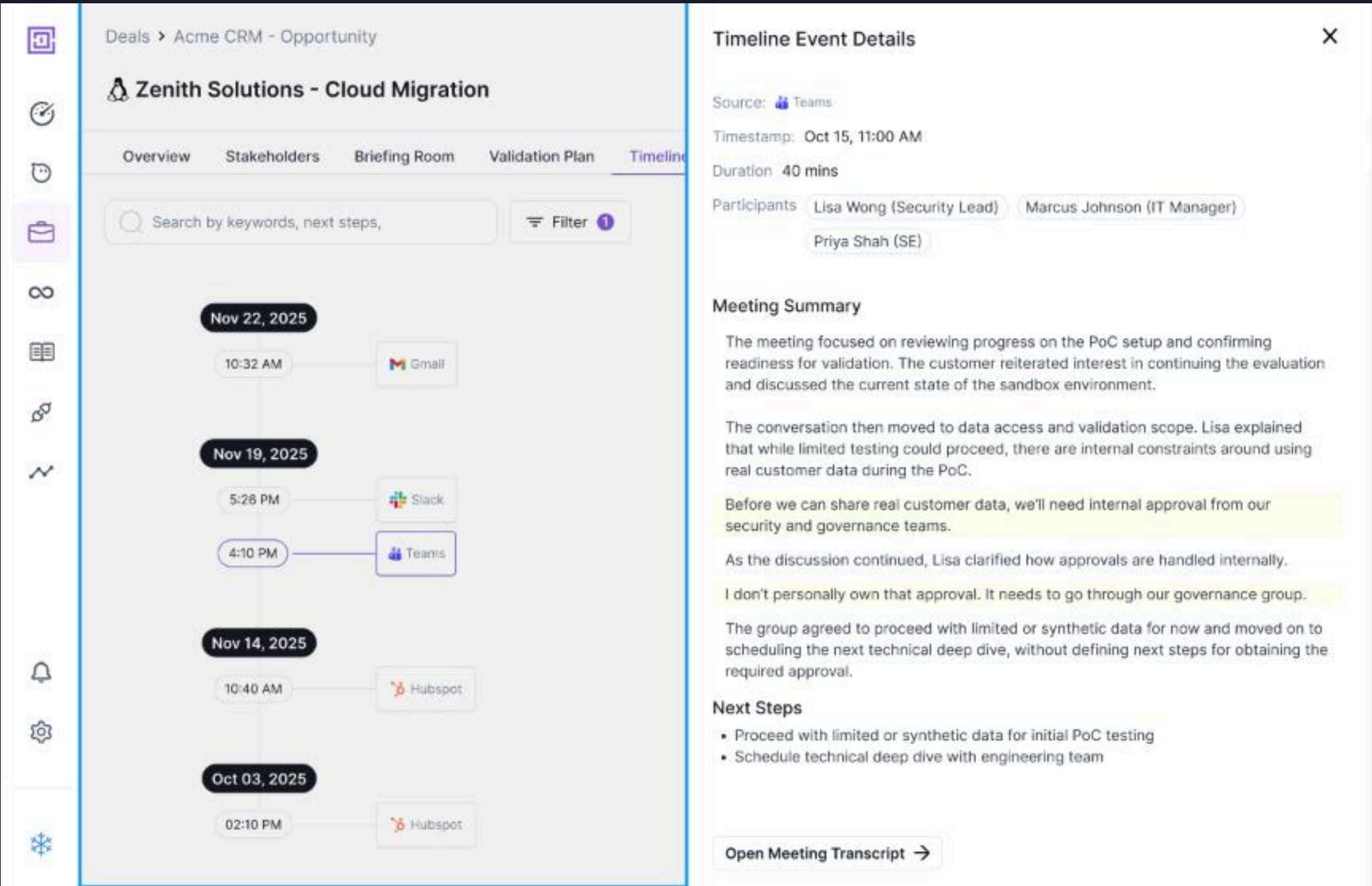
We brought together events from sources such as:

- Email
- Slack
- Teams
- CRM

The timeline made it possible to see:

what happened → when it happened → who was involved → what changed

This became especially important as our product thesis shifted toward deal momentum over time.



05. Understand the buying committee

This was one of the most important product concepts OF CopilotGTM. A CRM contact list can tell you who is involved. It cannot necessarily tell you:

- Who has influence
- Who supports the deal
- Who can block it
- What each person wants
- Who is missing
- How the stakeholder group is changing

We created Buying Committee Intelligence. The system built a map of the stakeholders involved in the deal.

It could identify people through meetings, email threads and calendar activity and enrich their context.

For each stakeholder, we could understand things such as:

- Role
- Motivation
- Influence
- Stance
- Champion potential
- Relationship to the deal

The interface represented supporters, neutral stakeholders and blockers visually.

The underlying idea -

A sales team should not just know:

- Who is involved?

It should know:

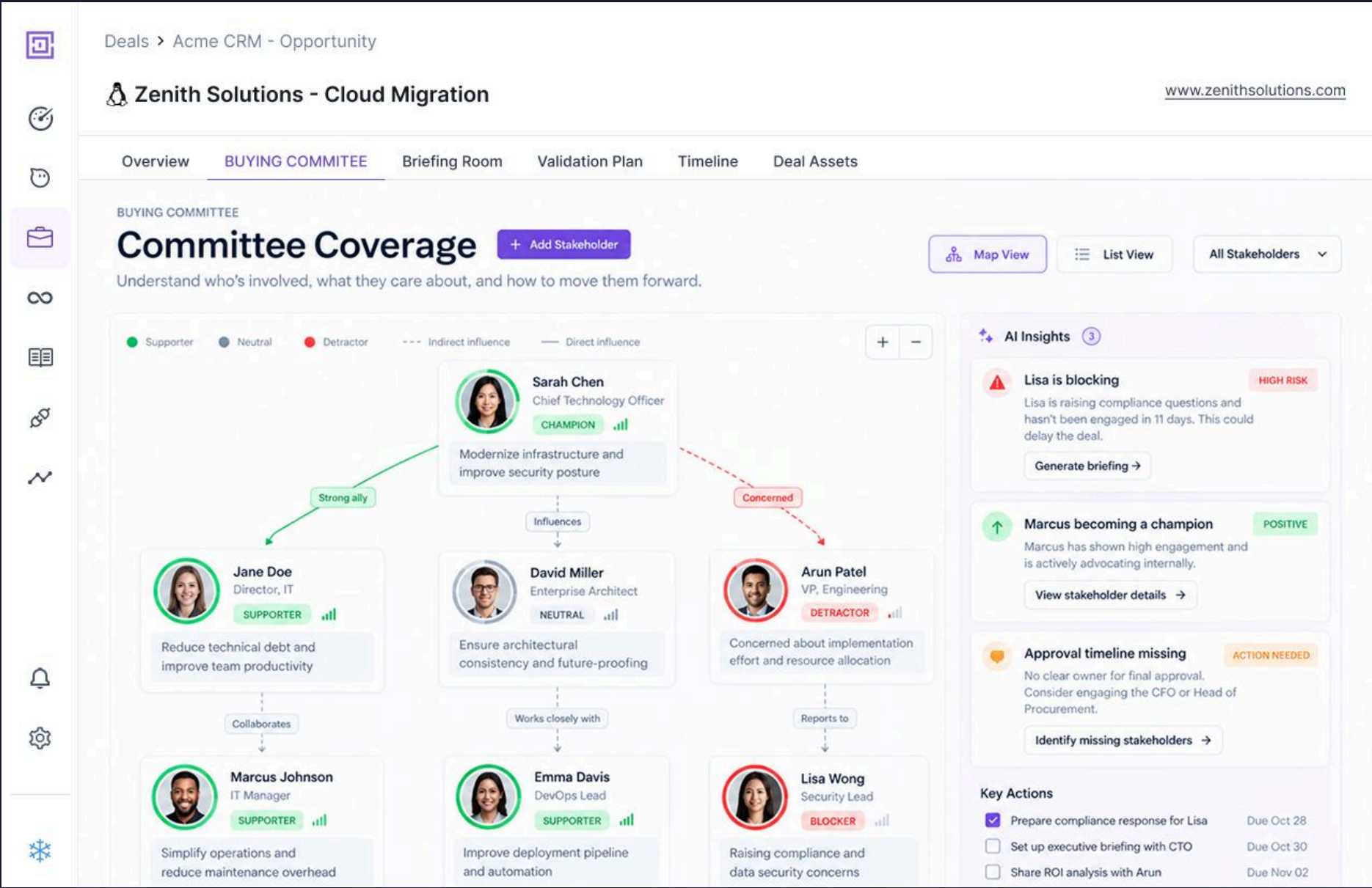
- Who matters, what do they want, how much influence do they have, and what should we do about it?

That led to concepts such as:



The value was not the org chart itself.

The value was connecting people to deal progression.



06. Turn product gaps into business evidence

We noticed another problem during customer conversations.
Salespeople regularly heard requests for missing product capabilities.
The problem was getting Product to prioritize them.

A salesperson might say:

"The customer wants SAP integration."

That was not enough.
The Product team needed to understand:

How many customers are asking for it?

Which deals are affected?

What revenue is at stake?

How strong is the evidence?

Product Insights

We created a system for aggregating product gaps from sales conversations and connecting them to potential revenue impact.

This created a connection between:

Customer conversation → Product gap → Revenue impact → Product prioritization

We later deprioritized this area as the roadmap evolved.
That was an important product decision too. Not every useful capability deserved to remain in the MVP.

07. Bring fragmented knowledge together

Another recurring problem was scattered information.

Customers had:

- RFPs
- Proposals
- Product documents
- Sales methodology
- Internal knowledge
- Websites
- Documentation

We created a Knowledge Base where these sources could be brought together.

The system could use that context to answer questions and support sales workflows.

We also explored integrations with tools such as:

- Google Drive, OneDrive
- Calendars, Emails
- Teams & Slack,
- Salesforce, HubSpot, Gong and Sybill

We increasingly designed the product as a layer connecting information from the tools sales teams already used.

08. Move from automation to agents

We also explored a more proactive model.

Traditional automation says:

When X happens, do Y.

We wanted the system to be able to interpret context first.

For example:

Trigger:

A member of the buying committee has not responded for several days.

Instead of automatically sending an email, an AI agent could first determine:

Is this a normal delay?

Is engagement declining?

Is there a known blocker?

Is a different action more appropriate?

The system could then recommend or initiate an action such as generating an email or scheduling a meeting.

This was part of our broader thinking about AI not just as a text generator, but as a mechanism for understanding context and taking action.

The product architecture evolved with the problem

As the product expanded, the information architecture started to reflect the underlying sales problem.

- Context
- Overview
- Timeline
- CRM information
- People
- Stakeholders
- Buying Committee
- Execution
- Briefing Room
- Validation Plan
- Deal Assets
- Intelligence
- Risks
- Product Gaps
- AI Insights

The navigation was not just a collection of features.

It reflected the mental model we were building:

Understand the deal → understand the people → understand what is happening → decide what to do next.

How I made product decisions

CopilotGTM did not have a separate product manager. That meant I moved between product design and product management.

I worked across:

- Customer discovery
- JTBD
- Product strategy
- Roadmap
- Feature prioritization
- PRDs
- Sprint planning
- Success metrics
- Pricing
- UX
- Information architecture

My approach was straightforward:

- Start with the customer's actual workflow.
- Understand what they do today.
- Identify the underlying Job-to-be-Done.
- Don't simply reproduce the customer's feature request.
- Test the business value.
- Who benefits?
- Who owns the outcome?
- Who owns the budget?
- Decide what not to build.

A startup roadmap is also a list of things you consciously say no to.

Build, learn and change the roadmap.

Our biggest roadmap change was also our biggest product decision:

Presales → Revenue Intelligence

The commercial lesson

The biggest lesson from CopilotGTM was not about AI. It was about validation.

Our first product had:

- Real users
- Design partners
- Positive feedback
- A product people liked

And yet that was not enough.

We had validated:

"This helps me."

We had not validated:

"My company will spend money on this."

That changed how I approach product discovery.

Today, I would validate four things before investing heavily in the product:

- User
- Problem
- Buyer
- Budget

What changed in my product thinking

Before CopilotGTM, I thought of product discovery largely as understanding the user's problem well enough to build the right solution.

After CopilotGTM, I think of validation as a chain:

User pain → Business outcome → Buyer → Budget → Product

A product can succeed at one step and fail at the next.

That was the most important lesson I took from building CopilotGTM.

Outcome

We did not end with a clean "we launched and grew 10x" story, and I would not try to manufacture one.

What we did achieve was meaningful product validation at two different stages.

- Initial product
- 5 U.S. presales design partners
- Used the product for several weeks and responded positively.
- The commercial problem exposed was budget ownership.

After the pivot:

- we onboarded 3 to 4 pilot customers, including a couple of paid pilots.

The product had evolved from a narrow presales assistant into a much broader revenue intelligence platform spanning deal context, preparation, follow-up, stakeholders, risks, product insights, knowledge and AI-assisted workflows.

The most important outcome was not a vanity metric.

It was that customer discovery materially changed the product, persona, positioning, pricing and roadmap.

What I would do differently

I would validate the economic buyer much earlier.

We spent meaningful effort making the initial product useful for presales users before fully validating whether those users could unlock budget.

Today, I would ask much earlier:

Who experiences the problem?

Who owns the outcome?

Who controls the budget?

What event causes them to spend money?

That would have changed what we built first.

The takeaway

CopilotGTM taught me that product design is not just about making a workflow easier.
Sometimes the most important design decision happens before the interface exists.

It is deciding:

Which problem is actually worth solving, for whom, and why will they pay for it?

That is what turned CopilotGTM from a presales assistant into a revenue intelligence product.